



Negotiating the Rate

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 9 of 18 · Getting the Load · about a 14-minute read

Two dispatchers, the same load on the board, posted at a thousand dollars. The first one calls, hears "a thousand," says "sounds good," and books it. Done in ninety seconds. The second one calls, but she happens to know this lane usually pays more than that, and she remembers the broker is making a margin on top of whatever he pays her — so there's room. She says, calmly, "I can do it for eleven-fifty." A little back-and-forth, and she books the exact same load for a hundred and fifty more.

Same truck. Same driver. Same miles. A hundred and fifty extra dollars for one phone call. Now do that on every load, all year long — that's the difference between a carrier that's scraping by and one that's comfortable.

The second dispatcher wasn't smarter or more aggressive. She just knew her numbers and wasn't afraid to ask. Negotiating isn't a personality trait you're born with — it's a skill, it's expected in this business, and by the end of this lesson it'll be yours.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Walk into the rate conversation with a target and a floor you've worked out in advance, open with a confident number, push back and justify when the broker counters, and know exactly when a load isn't worth taking and it's time to walk away. You'll stop accepting whatever's posted and start booking loads at rates you're proud of.

1 The Mindset: Negotiating Is Normal, and the Broker Has Room

The biggest thing standing between a new dispatcher and better rates isn't skill — it's nerve. So let's fix the mindset first. The posted rate is a *starting point*, not a price tag. Brokers fully expect carriers to negotiate; it's a normal, everyday part of how freight gets priced, and pushing back politely doesn't make you difficult — it makes you a professional running a business.

And here's the fact that should give you confidence, straight from the money lesson: the broker is getting paid *more* by the shipper than he's offering you. That difference is his **margin**, and it means there is almost always room above the first number he throws out. You're not begging him for a favor — you're two businesses agreeing on a fair price, and you both know there's a spread in there. The dispatcher who never negotiates isn't being polite; he's quietly the lowest-paid person in this whole business, leaving money on the table every single load.

ONE RULE THAT KEEPS IT CLEAN

Negotiation is *calm, friendly, and backed by numbers* — never emotional, never aggressive. You'll win far more with a steady "here's what I need and why" than with any hardball.

2 Know Your Two Numbers Before You Say a Word

You can't negotiate well if you don't know where you're going. So before the rate ever comes up, you set two numbers — and you set them *before* the call, as part of your prep.

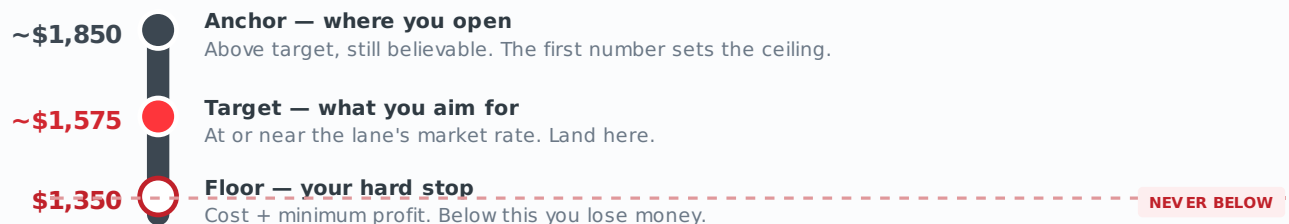
Your floor

This is the lowest rate you can accept and still make money. It comes straight from your cost — remember your cost-per-mile from the load-board lesson. Run the miles, find what the load costs you to haul, and your **floor** is the number that covers that cost plus the minimum profit that makes the load worth your truck. **Below your floor, you are losing money or working for free — so you never, ever go below it.** The floor is your hard stop.

Your target

This is the rate you're actually aiming for: fair, profitable, and in line with what the lane really pays — the **market rate**. You find market rate from the load board, rate tools, and experience: what loads on this lane between these cities generally go for right now. Your **target rate** should sit at or near that market number.

Floor and target. Once you know both, the whole negotiation has a shape — you aim to land at your target, you'll settle somewhere above your floor if you have to, and you walk if you can't even hit the floor:



Knowing these cold is what lets you sound calm and certain on the phone, instead of doing nervous math while the broker waits.

3 Anchor: Put Your Number Out First, and Aim High

Here's the most powerful move in the whole conversation, and most beginners get it backwards: **don't passively react to the broker's number — put yours out there first, and open a little above your target.** This is called *anchoring*, and it works because the first number said tends to pull the entire negotiation toward it. If you let the broker anchor low with the posted rate, you spend the whole call clawing your way up from his number. If you anchor first and high, he's working down toward *yours*.

So if a load's posted at nine hundred, the lane really pays around a thousand, and that's your target — you might open at eleven or twelve hundred. Said simply and calmly: *"I can do that load for twelve hundred."* Then stop talking, and let him respond. You've just set the ceiling of the conversation near your target instead of near his posting.

ANCHOR HIGH, NOT CRAZY

Your opening number should be above your target but still in the realm of what the lane could bear. A wildly unrealistic anchor doesn't pull the deal your way — it just tells the broker you don't know the market, and you lose credibility. Aim high, stay believable.

4 Counter and Justify: the Back-and-Forth

The broker will almost always counter — usually back down near his posted number. Now you negotiate toward your target, and two habits make all the difference.

Counter in steps, and protect your target

Don't leap from your anchor straight to your floor the moment he pushes — that throws away everything in between. Come down a little, hold near your target, and make him meet you. Patience here is literally worth money.

Justify every number

This is the secret that turns "I want more" into "here's the fair number." Give the broker a *reason* he can say yes to: the lane's market rate, a deadhead you're covering to reach the pickup, a tight pickup or delivery window, the fuel and miles, your truck's reliability and on-time service. *"Nine hundred's under market for this lane, and I've got a deadhead to cover to get there — I need eleven hundred to make it work."* A justified number is easy to agree to; a bare demand is easy to refuse.

And don't over-talk. State your number and your reason, then let silence do some of the work — beginners talk themselves down while the broker says nothing. Your aim is to land at or above your target. If you have to give ground, you give it slowly, down toward — but never below — your floor.

5 Know When to Walk Away (and How to Close When You Don't)

The single most powerful thing you have in any negotiation is your willingness to say no. If the broker won't come up to a number that at least clears your floor, you **walk away** — politely. *"I appreciate it, but I just can't make that one work. If anything changes on the rate, give me a call."* And mean it.

Walking matters for three reasons. **First, it protects you** — a load below your floor *loses* you money and ties up your truck so it can't take a better one; sometimes no load really is better than a bad load. **Second, it often works** — the broker has a margin and a load he needs to move, and "no" frequently brings him back ten minutes later with a better number. **Third, it keeps your floor meaningful** — a floor you'll actually hold is a floor brokers learn to respect. There is always another load. Don't take a bad one out of fear.

And when you *do* land on a number you'll accept — at or above your floor — close it cleanly. Confirm the number out loud, and roll it straight into booking the load: "*Ten-fifty works — send the rate confirmation over.*" Don't keep haggling after you've agreed; that just annoys the broker and risks the deal. Agree, lock it, done. (That agreed number is what goes onto the rate confirmation — the document that makes it official, which is its own lesson.)

Walkthrough — One Negotiation, Start to Finish

A fresh one-off load (not our anchor load). Summit's known cost is about \$1.85 a mile. Read it as your negotiation script.

The setup — a load on the board. Lane: Dallas → Memphis, ~450 loaded miles. Posted: **\$1,300** (a bit under market for this lane). Your cost (~\$1.85/mi × ~470 mi incl. a short deadhead): ≈ **\$870**.
FLOOR \$1,350 — covers cost + minimum profit, never below. **TARGET \$1,575** — the lane's market rate. **ANCHOR \$1,850** — open above target, believable.

YOU "I can do the Dallas-Memphis load for eighteen-fifty." **ANCHOR HIGH**

BROKER "It's posted at thirteen."

YOU
"Thirteen's under market for this lane, and I've a deadhead to cover to get to the pickup — I can come to sixteen-fifty."
COUNTER + JUSTIFY

BROKER "I can do fourteen-fifty."

YOU "Let's meet at fifteen-seventy-five." **HOLD NEAR TARGET**

BROKER "Fifteen hundred."

YOU "Fifteen hundred works — send the rate confirmation over." **CLEAN CLOSE**

→ **Booked at \$1,500** — above the \$1,350 floor, just under the \$1,575 target. A dispatcher who took the posted \$1,300 left \$200 on the table — on one call.

The other outcome — walk away. If the broker's best is **\$1,250** (below your \$1,350 floor): "*I appreciate it, but I can't make twelve-fifty work. If the rate changes, give me a call.*" → You pass. There's another load, and the door's left open.

Watch what carried that negotiation: she knew her floor and target before she dialed, she anchored above target instead of reacting to the posting, every number came with a reason, she held near her target instead of caving, and she closed clean the second the number worked. And in the other outcome, the floor did its job — twelve-fifty loses money, so she walked, with the door left open. That's the whole skill.

Module 9 Glossary — your quick reference

The three numbers that shape every rate conversation.

Your negotiation numbers

Target rate	The fair, profitable rate you're aiming for — at or near the lane's market rate. Where you try to land.
Rate floor (floor)	The lowest rate that still covers your cost plus a minimum profit. Your hard stop — never go below it.
Market rate	What loads on a given lane generally pay right now — read from the load board, rate tools, and experience. Your target sits at or near it.
Broker margin	The spread between what the shipper pays the broker and what the broker pays you — the room that makes negotiation possible (from the money lesson).

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

- 1. Why is it fair — not pushy — to negotiate a posted rate?**
- 2. What are your floor and your target, and where does each come from?**
- 3. A load is posted at \$1,300; the lane pays ~\$1,575; your floor is \$1,350. Roughly what do you open with, and why?**
- 4. The broker counters lower. Name two justifications you can give for your number.**
- 5. The broker won't go above \$1,250 and your floor is \$1,350. What do you do, and why?**

ANSWERS

1. The posted rate is a starting point and brokers expect negotiation; the broker earns a margin on top of what he pays you, so there's usually room above the first number. It's two businesses agreeing on a fair price.
2. Floor = the lowest rate that still covers your cost plus minimum profit (from your cost-per-mile) — never go below it. Target = the fair, profitable rate you're aiming for, at or near the lane's market rate.
3. Open above your target — around \$1,800-\$1,900 — to anchor high and leave room to come down to ~\$1,575. Don't passively accept the \$1,300.
4. Any two of: the lane's market rate, a deadhead you're covering, a tight pickup/delivery window, fuel and miles, your reliability and on-time service.
5. Walk away politely — a load below your floor loses money and ties up the truck; there's always another load, and the broker often calls back with a better number.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 10: SETTING APPOINTMENTS

Now you can book a load and negotiate a rate you're actually proud of. The load is yours, at a number that works. But before your driver can roll, there's scheduling to lock down — exactly when and where he picks up and delivers, and how those appointment windows really work. Get that wrong and a great rate quietly turns into wasted hours sitting at a dock and a delivery that's late through no fault of the driver. Next, we set the appointments.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches negotiation with generic numbers and the universal anchor-counter-walk skill. Your own operation adds its specifics — its target and floor guidance by lane and equipment and how it expects floors calculated from cost; the rate tools it uses to read current market rates; how hard it wants you to push and its specific walk-away rules; its preferred phrasing for anchoring, countering, and declining; and when to escalate a key broker who won't meet rate. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*